Colonoscopy preparation

A colonoscopy examines the inside of the large bowel with a camera. The bowel must be completely empty for the camera to see clearly, so the preparation starts several days before your appointment.

Seven days before

Stop iron tablets. If you take blood thinners such as warfarin, apixaban or clopidogrel, or medicines for diabetes, ask your clinician whether to change them; do not stop them yourself.

Two days before

Eat a low-fibre diet: white bread, white rice, pasta, chicken, fish, eggs and potatoes without skin. Avoid fruit, vegetables, nuts, seeds and wholegrain foods.

The day before

Have a light breakfast, then clear fluids only: water, clear soup, black tea or coffee, and clear apple juice. Take the bowel preparation laxative exactly as instructed on the packet, usually in two doses, and stay near a toilet.

On the day

Continue clear fluids until two hours before the procedure, then nothing by mouth. You may be offered sedation; if so, someone must take you home and stay with you for twelve hours, and you must not drive until the next day.